

The following outline is provided as an overview of and topical guide to World War II:

World War II, or the Second World War was a global military conflict that was fought between September 1, 1939, and September 2, 1945. The war pitted two major military alliances against each other: the Allies of the United States, Soviet Union, United Kingdom, China and others against the Axis of Germany, Japan, Italy and others. Over 60 million people, the majority of them civilians, were killed, making it the deadliest conflict in human history.

The Second World War was known for modern warfare and tactics such as air warfare, strategic bombing, blitzkrieg and the first, and only, use of nuclear weapons in warfare. It is also known for the numerous war crimes committed during its duration, mostly by Axis forces but also by Allied forces, that left tens of millions of civilians dead through genocides, massacres and starvation; such as the Holocaust, Three Alls Policy, Genocide of ethnic Poles, Unit 731, Nanjing massacre, Hunger Plan and the Warsaw Uprising.

Causes of World War II

World War I

Treaty of Versailles

Imperialism, expansionism and nationalism

Expansionist nationalism

Lebensraum

Japanese nationalism

Events preceding World War II in Europe

Fascism in Europe

National Fascist Party

Benito Mussolini

Nazi Party

Adolf Hitler

Events preceding World War II in Asia

Statism in Shōwa Japan

Japanese invasion of Manchuria

Xi'an Incident

Second Sino-Japanese War

Participants in World War II

The Axis powers

Major Axis powers

Germany

Japan

Italy

Other Axis powers

Hungary

Romania

Slovakia

Bulgaria

Croatia

Finland

The Allied powers

The 'Big Five' major allies

Soviet Union

United States

United Kingdom

China

France

Other major allies

Poland

Yugoslavia

Greece

Canada

Netherlands

Belgium

Czechoslovakia

India

Australia

People in World War II

Leaders in World War II

Axis leaders

Adolf Hitler – Führer (leader) of Germany

Hirohito – Emperor of Japan

Benito Mussolini – Prime Minister and Duce of Italy

Allied leaders

Joseph Stalin – Leader of the Soviet Union

Franklin D. Roosevelt – President of the United States

Winston Churchill – Prime Minister of the United Kingdom

Chiang Kai-shek – Leader of China

Military forces of World War II

List of World War II aces by country

List of World War II air aces

British Army during the Second World War

History of the Royal Navy

British Army Groups in WWII

British Corps in World War II List of British Commonwealth divisions in the Second World War

Canada in World War II

Indian Army during World War II

Military history of France during World War II

Army of Africa

French Liberation Army

French Expeditionary Corps

Armistice Army (Vichy)

Vichy French Air Force

Milice (French Militia)

Military history of the United States during World War II

List of formations of the United States Army during World War II

United States Navy in World War II

United States Army Air Forces

American Minority Groups in World War II

Military history of the Soviet Union

Red Army

Military units and formations of the Soviet Union in World War II

Field armies of the Soviet Union

National Revolutionary Army

Army groups of the National Revolutionary Army

Military history of Germany

Wehrmacht

Heer

Luftwaffe

Kriegsmarine

Waffen-SS

Gestapo

Afrika Korps (DAK)

List of German divisions in World War II

Military history of Japan

Imperial Japanese Armed Forces

Imperial Japanese Army

Imperial Japanese Army Air Service

Imperial Japanese Navy

Imperial Japanese Navy Air Service

Imperial Japanese Navy Land Forces

List of Japanese Infantry divisions

Military history of Italy during World War II

List of Italian divisions in World War II

Royal Italian Army

Regia Marina

Regia Aeronautica

Blackshirts (MVSN)

Timeline of World War II

The following list includes some of the largest events in World War II:

1939

August 23: Germany and the Soviet Union sign a non-aggression pact

September 1: Germany invades Poland, beginning the war

September 3: War is declared on Germany by the United Kingdom and France, the Battle of the Atlantic and Phoney War begins

September 17: After the Soviet Union defeats Japan in Mongolia, they invade Poland as well

November 30: The Soviet Union invades Finland

1940

April 9: Germany invades Denmark and Norway

May 10: Germany invades France and the low countries

May 26: British troops evacuate Dunkirk

June 10: Italy declares war on United Kingdom and France

July 10: Germany begins an air campaign against Britain

September 7: Germany begins a major bombing campaign against Britain

1941

June 22: Germany invades the Soviet Union

September 8: The Siege of Leningrad begins

October 2: The Battle of Moscow begins

December 7: Japan attacks Pearl Harbor, bringing the United States into the war

1942

February 8: Fall of Singapore

May 4: Battle of the Coral Sea

June 4: Battle of Midway

July 1: First Battle of El Alamein

July 17: Battle of Stalingrad

August 19: Dieppe Raid

October 23: Second Battle of El Alamein

November 8: Operation Torch

1943

July 4: Battle of Kursk

July 9: Allied invasion of Sicily

September 3: Allied invasion of Italy and surrender of Italy

1944

January 17: Battle of Monte Cassino

January 22: Landings at Anzio

April 19: Operation Ichi-Go

June 6: D-Day

June 22: Destruction of Army Group Center

August 1: Warsaw Uprising

August 15: Invasion of Southern France

September 17: Operation Market Garden

September 19: Battle of Hürtgen Forest

October 23: Battle of Leyte Gulf

December 16: Battle of the Bulge

1945

April 16 - May 2: Battle of Berlin

May 8: Victory in Europe Day

August 6 and 9: Atomic bombings of Hiroshima and Nagasaki

August 15: Victory over Japan Day

September 2: Surrender of Japan

World War II by region

Theatres and major campaigns

Europe

Eastern front

Western front

Mediterranean and Middle Eastern theatre

Italian Campaign

Arctic theatre

Arctic convoys

Asia

Second Sino-Japanese War

South-East Asian Theatre

Pacific Ocean theatre

Africa

For all theatres in Africa, see: African theatres

North African campaign

West Africa campaign

East African campaign

Other

Home front during World War II

By country

Europe

Albania

Albania under Italy

Belarus

Bulgaria

Bulgarian resistance movement during World War II

Carpathian Ruthenia

Estonia

Occupation of Estonia by Nazi Germany

Finland

France

Germany

Gibraltar

Greece

Axis occupation of Greece during World War II

Hungary

Ireland

Italy

Italian Campaign

Allied invasion of Sicily

Allied invasion of Italy

Latvia

Occupation of Latvia by Nazi Germany

Leningrad Oblast

Netherlands

Soviet Union

Spain

United Kingdom

Yugoslavia

Invasion of Yugoslavia

Occupation of Baltic republics by Nazi Germany

Occupation of Belarus by Nazi Germany

Occupation of Denmark

German occupation of the Channel Islands

History of Poland (1939–1945)

Occupation of Poland (1939–1945)

Administrative division of Polish territories during World War II

War crimes in occupied Poland during World War II

Polish culture during World War II

Romania

Asia

Burma

India

Nepal

Philippines

Vietnam

Africa

Algeria

Egypt

South Africa

Southern Rhodesia

Oceania

Australia

New Zealand

Axis naval activity in New Zealand waters

The Americas

United States

Canada

Greenland

War crimes

The Second World War was characterized by many instances of War crimes:

Genocide

The Holocaust

Nazism

Nazi Party

Nazi eugenics

Political views of Adolf Hitler

Anti-Jewish legislation in prewar Nazi Germany

Diary of Anne Frank

Nazi book burnings

Nazi ghettos

Nazi concentration camps

Nazi extermination camps

Auschwitz

Belzec

Chełmno

Majdanek

Sobibor

Treblinka

History of Jews in Europe

History of the Jews during World War II

List of major perpetrators of the Holocaust

Nazi human experimentation

Racial policy of Nazi Germany

Persecution of homosexuals in Nazi Germany and the Holocaust

List of individuals and groups assisting Jews during the Holocaust

Other genocides

Nazi genocide of ethnic Poles

Romani genocide

Massacres

Three Alls Policy

Nanjing massacre

Massacres during the Warsaw Uprising

Wola massacre

Ochota massacre

Katyn massacre

Mistreatment of civilians

Comfort women

Unit 731

Rape during the occupation of Germany

Population transfer in the Soviet Union

Technology during World War II

Technology during World War II

[German military technology during World War II](#)

[Allied technological cooperation during World War II](#)

[Technological escalation during World War II](#)

[Equipment of World War II](#)

[Lists of World War II military equipment](#)

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[Vehicles of World War II](#)

[List of World War II military vehicles by country](#)

[List of World War II military vehicles of Germany](#)

[List of World War II ship classes](#)

[List of World War II ships](#)

[List of World War II ships of less than 1000 tons](#)

[List of WW2 Luftwaffe aircraft by manufacturer](#)

[List of aircraft of Italy, World War II](#)

[List of aircraft of Japan, World War II](#)

[List of ships of the Imperial Japanese Navy](#)

[List of aircraft of Russia, World War II](#)

[List of aircraft of World War II](#)

[List of aircraft of the French Air Force during World War II](#)

[List of aircraft of the British, World War II](#)

[List of aircraft of the Luftwaffe, World War II](#)

[List of aircraft of the U.S. military, World War II](#)

[List of armored fighting vehicles of World War II](#)

[List of broadsides of major World War II ships](#)

List of undersea-carried planes during World War II

List of weapons on Japanese combat aircraft

List of prototype WWII combat vehicles

List of foreign vehicles used by Nazi Germany in World War II

List of helicopters used in World War II

List of jet aircraft of World War II

Weapons of World War II

List of World War II weapons

List of World War II infantry weapons

List of World War II firearms of Germany

Other initiatives in World War II

Nazi plunder

Propaganda during World War II

Black propaganda

World War II political cartoons

List of Allied propaganda films of World War II

American propaganda during World War II

Walt Disney's World War II propaganda production

British propaganda during World War II

Propaganda and India in World War II

Soviet propaganda during World War II

Nazi propaganda

Propaganda in Fascist Italy

Propaganda in Japan during the Second Sino-Japanese War and World War II

Common military awards

Soviet Union

Hero of the Soviet Union

Order of Lenin

Order of Suworov

Order of the October Revolution

Order of the Red Banner

Order of Victory

United States

Medal of Honor

Purple Heart

Silver Star

Bronze Star

Distinguished Flying Cross

Air Medal

World War II Victory Medal

Asiatic-Pacific Campaign Medal

European-African-Middle Eastern Campaign Medal

American Campaign Medal

United Kingdom

Victoria Cross

Air Force Cross

Order of the Bath

Order of the British Empire

Distinguished Flying Cross

Africa Star

Pacific Star

France and Belgium

Croix de Guerre

Poland

Cross of the Valorous

Order of Polonia Restituta

Virtuti Militari

Nazi Germany

Orders, decorations, and medals of Nazi Germany

Iron Cross

Aftermath of World War II

The end of World War II

End of World War II in Europe

End of World War II in the Pacific

Immediate events

War reparations

Japanese reparations

Forced labor of Germans in the Soviet Union

Nuremberg trials

International Military Tribunal for the Far East

The post-war world

Cold War

Emergence of United States and USSR as global superpowers

NATO

Warsaw Pact

Iron Curtain

Proxy wars

Decolonization

Post-World War II baby boom

Pursuit of Nazi collaborators

World War II - related media

World War II in popular culture

The Holocaust in popular culture

List of World War II films

History books about World War II

See also

Lists of World War II topics

Opposition to World War II

Outline of war

Outline of World War I

Notes

References

Bibliography

Bix, Herbert P. (September 4, 2001). Hirohito and the making of modern Japan. HarperCollins. ISBN 978-0-06-093130-8. Retrieved April 6, 2022.

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